



Resolving semantic ambiguity via agreement: The case of Spanish Adjectival Conjuncts

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1. Empirical puzzle

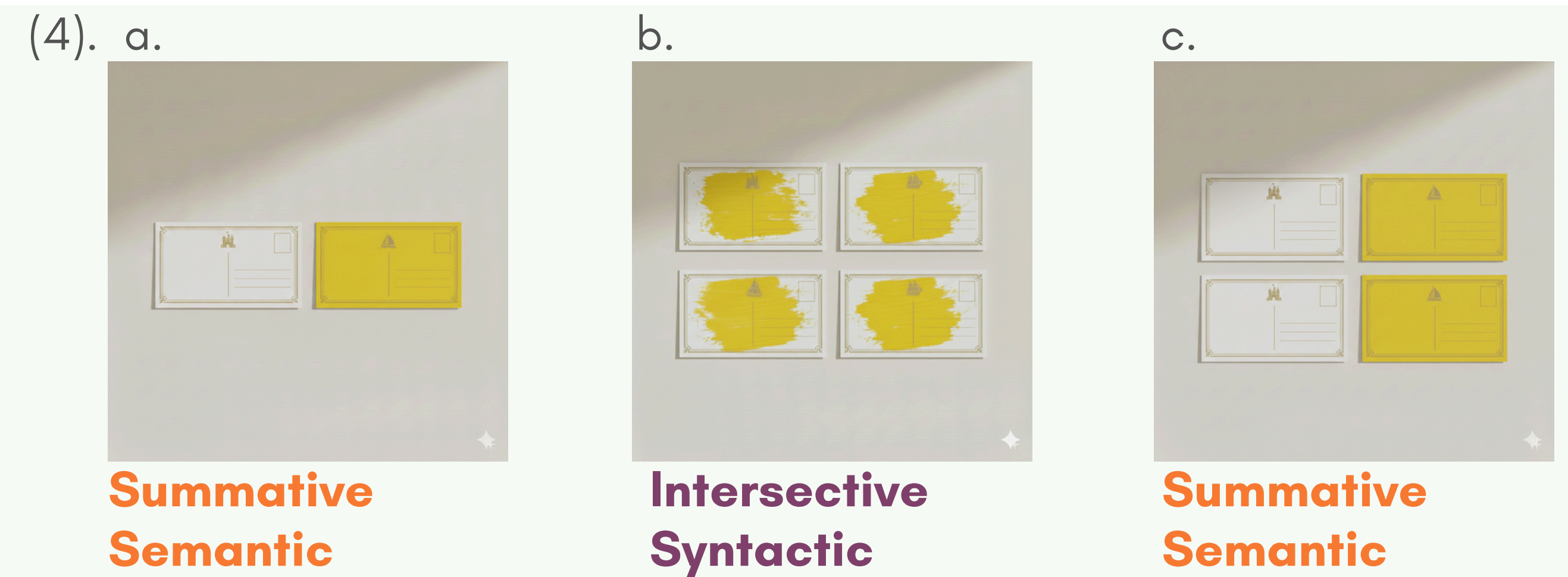
Conjoined class-term (*k*) adjectives modifying a PL noun trigger two readings: intersective OR summative

- Spanish Adjectival Conjuncts modifying a PL noun trigger **ambiguity** with **full agreement** [GEN and NUM]: (1) for **intersective** (4b) or **summative** (4a/c).

(1) Las tarjeta**a-s** blanc**-a-s** y amarill**-a-s**
The.FEM-PL card.FEM-PL white-FEM-PL and yellow-FEM-PL
'The white and yellow cards'

- Conjuncts with **default φ -features** ([MASC, SG]) only express **intersectivity**; a novel observation that has not been noted in prior literature: (2) for (4b).

(2) Las tarjeta**a-s** blanc**-o-o** y amarill**-o-o**
The.FEM-PL card.FEM-PL white-MASC-SG and yellow-MASC-SG
'The partially white and partially yellow cards'



- Conjuncts with **gender agreement** only ([FEM, SG]) express an **exactly-two summative** reading: (3) for (4a).

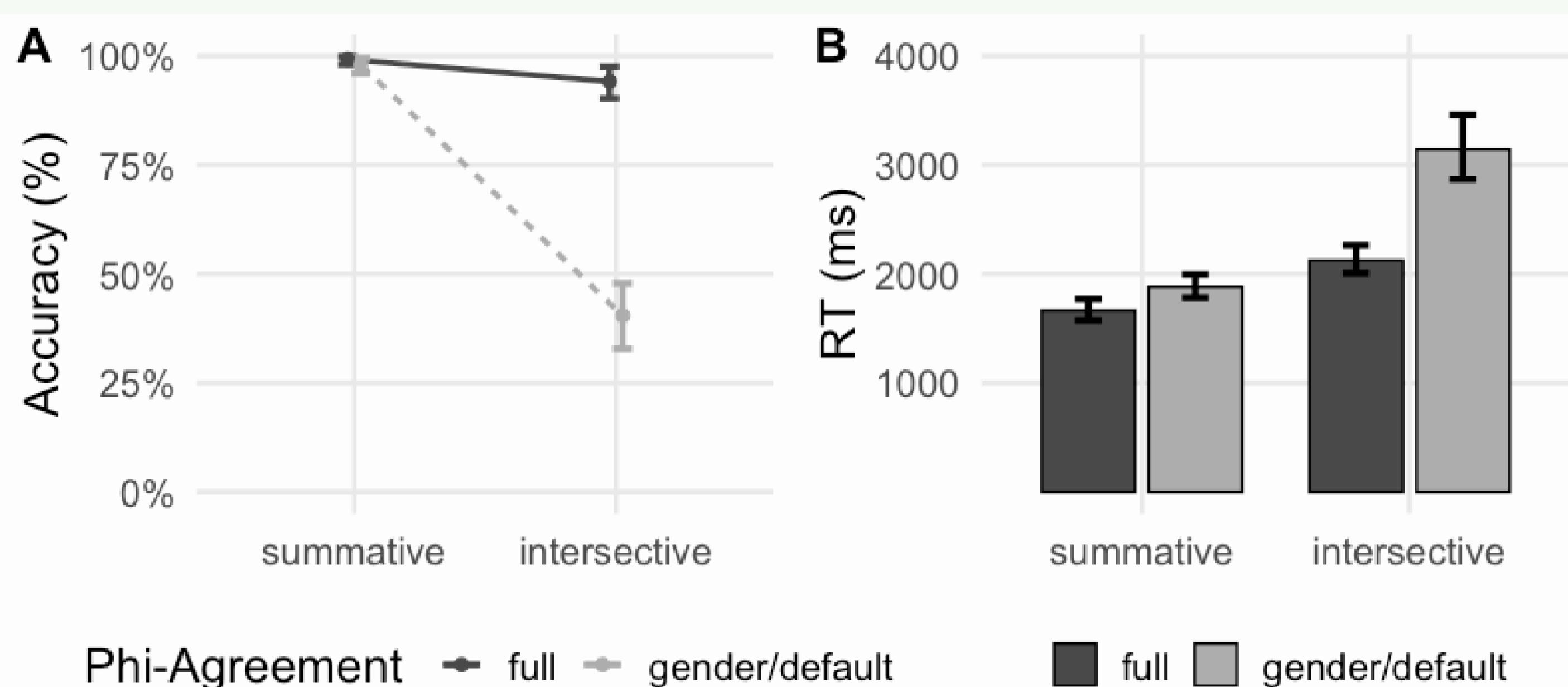
(3) Las tarjeta**a-s** blanc**-a-o** y amarill**-a-o**
The.FEM-PL card.FEM-PL white-FEM-SG and yellow-FEM-SG
'The white card and the yellow card'

→ **Are all these readings (equally) available to Spanish speakers?**

2. Picture selection task: Speakers (N = 60) use DP-internal φ -agreement to interpret Spanish PL conjuncts.

- Default agreement is available for some speakers,
- Intersective is less accessible than Summative,
- Gender agreement is less accessible than Full agreement.

Task: Participants previewed a target and a distractor picture for 3 s, listened to the sentences in (5) and selected the matching picture as fast as possible.



Means and 95% credible intervals of accuracy (A) and picture selection RTs starting from the end of the first adjective in correctly answered trials only (B).

(5) Selección las tarjeta-s... Select the cards (card.FEM-PL)...

a. **Summative** with **Full** vs. **Gender** Agreement:

(1) vs. (3) from above

Target Picture=Fig4a/4c

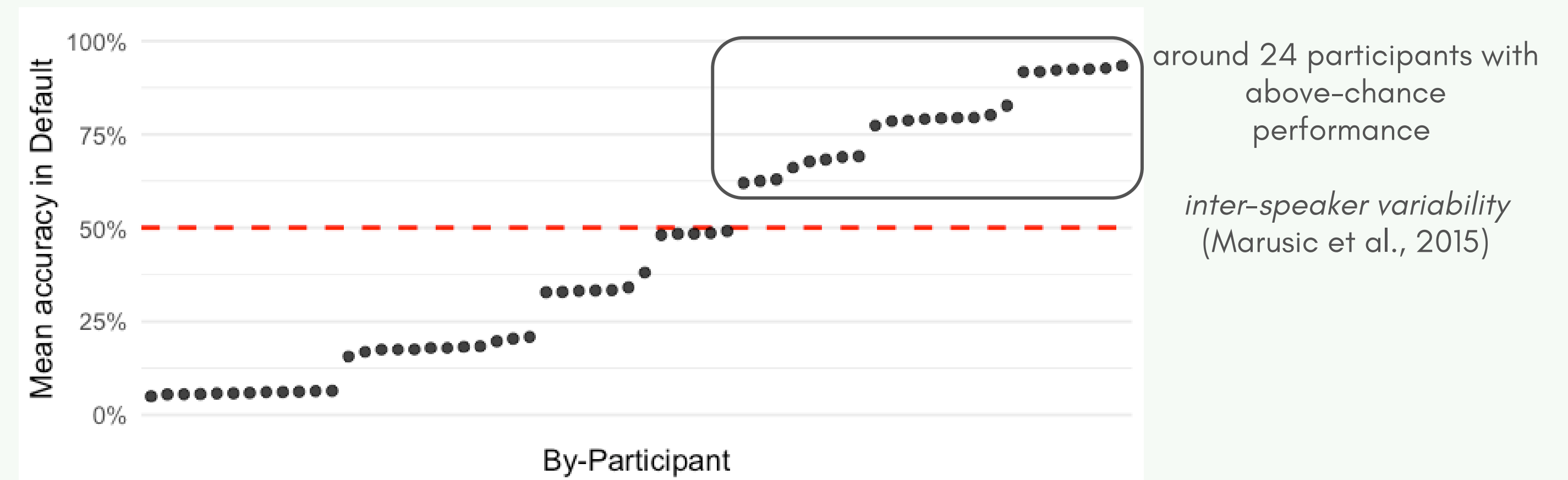
b. **Intersective** with **Full** vs. **Default** agreement:

(1) vs. (2) from above

Target Picture=Fig4b

Finding.1: Lowest accuracy & longest RTs with **default agreement**

→ **default agreement** is available, but for a subset of speakers



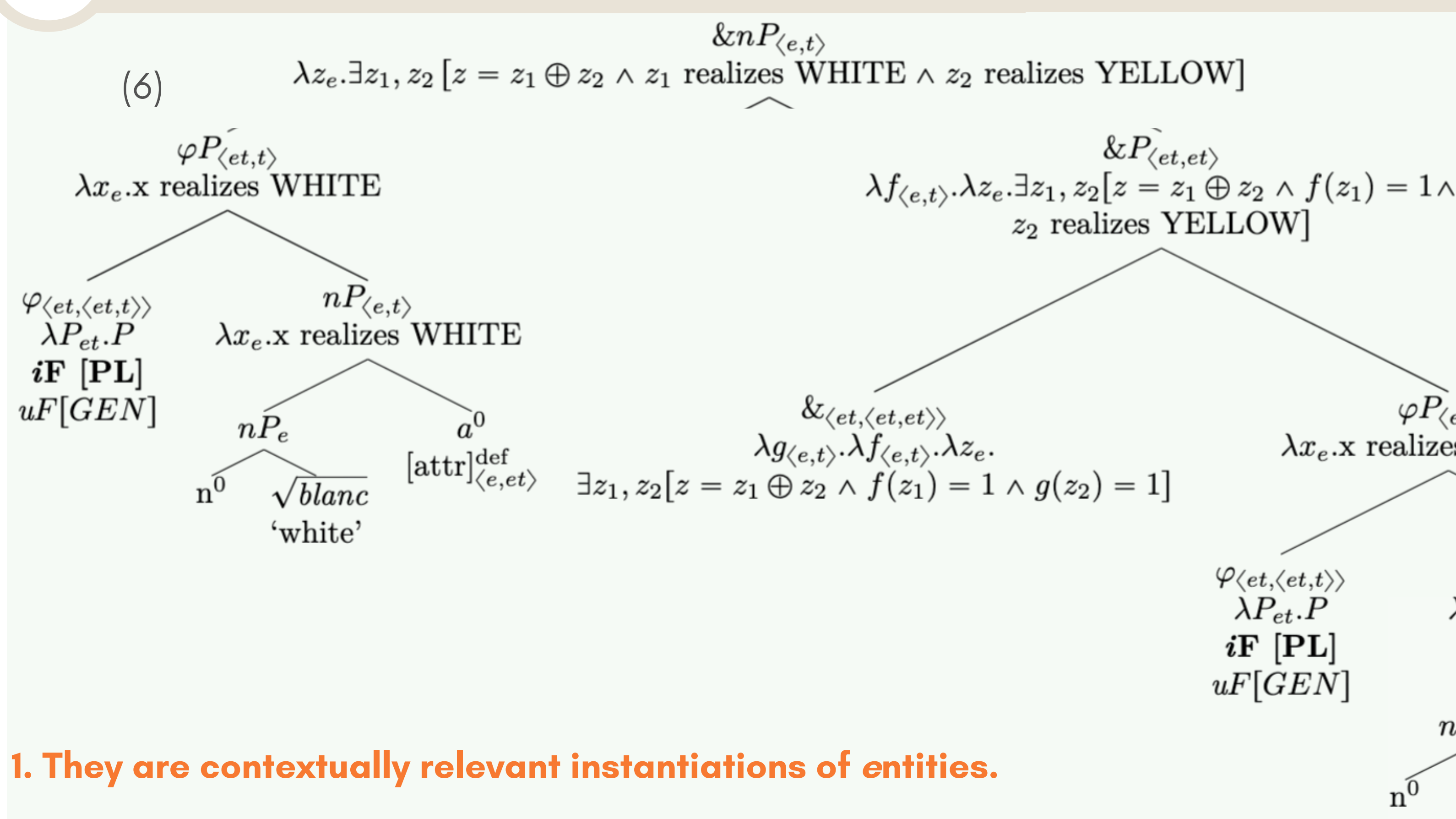
Finding.2: Longer RTs with **intersective** than summative in **full agreement**

→ due to the complexity of subatomicity

Finding.3: Longer RTs with **gender agreement** than full in **summative**

→ due to the presupposition introduced by iF[SG] (cf. Schwartz, 2015)

3. Compositional proposal: DM meets semantics. What's special about class-term adjectives?



1. They are contextually relevant instantiations of entities.

$[\text{attr}]^{\text{def}}$ denotes a function that takes an x of type e -kind and returns a property of an individual y such that x and y are in a contextually relevant Relation.

(8) $[[\text{attr}]^{\text{def}}] = \lambda x_e. \lambda y_e. y \text{ is related to } x$ (Á la Borshev and Partee (1999) for possessives)

- nPs of type $\langle e, t \rangle$ cannot be derived as adjectives with $[\text{attr}]^{\text{def}}$
- e = individuals and kinds (Chierchia, 1984)

2. Denominal adjectives project valued interpretable Number-features.

iF[SG] → Exactly two atoms, see (2)

iF[PL] → Exactly two sets of ATOMS, see (3)

uF[SG/PL] → No Number semantics

3. The interaction of kind-derived adjectives with non-Boolean conjunction (Krifka, 2025) determines $[\varphi]$ syntactic valuation and semantic interpretation

Conjunction high $\langle e, t \rangle \langle e, t \rangle$: each nP projects its own set of φP

Conjunction low $\langle e, e \rangle$: a sole φP with uF: [PL] → full agreement

[SG] → default agreement

4. Contributions

- Our experimental findings show that Spanish speakers use **DP-internal φ -agreement to navigate different meanings.**
- This supports our compositional account positing **interactions between iF and uF within adjectival conjunctions.**
- Overall, our work connects to the **totality-partiality** discussion of color terms (Paillé 2025), **presupposition processing** (Schwarz, 2019), and the semantics and syntax of **conjunction** (Charnavel & Sportiche, 2025; Smith, 2017)